RSS Digest
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1. Millisecond Converter
Source: Simon Willison’s Weblog | Published: 2026-04-24T04:23:11+00:00
Link: https://simonwillison.net/2026/Apr/24/milliseconds/#atom-everything
Tool: Millisecond Converter LLM reports prompt durations in milliseconds and I got fed up of having to think about how to convert those to seconds and minutes. Tags: tools

2. It’s a big one
Source: Simon Willison’s Weblog | Published: 2026-04-24T04:09:54+00:00
Link: https://simonwillison.net/2026/Apr/24/weekly/#atom-everything
This week’s edition of my email newsletter (aka content from this blog delivered to your inbox) features 4 pelicans riding bicycles, 1 possum on an e-scooter, up to 5 raccoons with ham radios hiding in crowds, 5 blog posts, 8 links, 3 quotes and a new chapter of my Agentic Engineering Patterns guide. Tags: newsletter

3. russellromney/honker
Source: Simon Willison’s Weblog | Published: 2026-04-24T01:50:07+00:00
Link: https://simonwillison.net/2026/Apr/24/honker/#atom-everything
russellromney/honker "Postgres NOTIFY/LISTEN semantics" for SQLite, implemented as a Rust SQLite extension and various language bindings to help make use of it. The design of this looks very solid. It lets you write Python code for queues that looks like this: import honker db = honker . open ("app.db") emails = db . queue ("emails") emails . enqueue ({ "to" : "alice@example.com" }) # Consume (in a worker process) async for job in emails . claim ("worker-1"): send (job . payload) job . ack () And Kafka-style durable streams like this: stream = db . stream ("user-events") with db . transaction () as tx : tx . execute ("UPDATE users SET name=? WHERE id=?" , [name , uid]) stream . publish ({ "user_id" : uid , "change" : "name" }, tx = tx) async for event in stream . subscribe (consumer = "dashboard"): await push_to_browser (event) It also adds 20+ custom SQL functions including these two: SELECT notify(’ orders ’ , ’ {"id":42} ’); SELECT honker_stream_read_since(’ orders ’ , 0 , 1000); The extension requires WAL mode, and workers can poll the .db-wal file with a stat call every 1ms to get as close to real-time as possible without the expense of running a full SQ...

4. DF Paraphernalia: Last Call for This Round of T-Shirts and Hoodies
Source: Daring Fireball | Published: 2026-04-26T19:30:00Z
Link: https://store.daringfireball.net/
It?s really just a coincidence, but it was 20 years ago this week that I went full-time writing Daring Fireball (after writing the site in my spare time for 4 years). That feels like a long time ago. But it feels like yesterday, too. In my announcement, I wrote : Daring Fireball is what I love to do. That remains as true today than it was then. Whether you?re a longtime reader or a relatively new one, you might enjoy reading that piece from 20 years ago. So far, so good. (I?ve got some readers who were only small children when I wrote that. I occasionally hear from some who weren?t even born then.) There might be other ways you can support my work directly in the future. But for now, the best way is to buy t-shirts and hoodies from my periodic sales. The current sale is going to end sometime tomorrow. If you?re seeing this post Sunday night and thinking about making a purchase, act now . If you?re seeing this Monday morning, you should really act now. ?

5. ? The New York Times Printed the Wrong Crossword Grid Last Sunday, and I Find That Timing Serendipitous
Source: Daring Fireball | Published: 2026-04-26T19:28:59Z
Link: https://daringfireball.net/2026/04/nyt_wrong_crossword_grid
Software brain says *Go faster; do more; the only mistake you can?t fix is having gone too slow.* Hardware brain says *Slow down; do less; focus; strive for perfection and never settle

for less than excellence; mistakes are forever.*

6. Report Claims Samsung Might Post Its First-Ever Mobile Division Loss This Year, Blaming RAM Crisis
Source: Daring Fireball | Published: 2026-04-26T17:39:40Z
Link: https://9to5google.com/2026/04/22/samsung-is-increasingly-worried-about-first-ever-mobile-division-loss-in-ram-crisis-report/
Ben Schoon, 9to5Google: In March, a report revealed some of the internal cuts Samsung has been making for its mobile division, with the company initially concerned it could post an operating loss for the first time ever. It?s a big deal, as Samsung?s mobile (MX) division has historically always turned a profit. A new report out of Korea (via Jukan) makes this seem all but certain. Apparently, Samsung?s TM Roh, the head of the company?s mobile division, has expressed concerns of the ?possibility of an annual deficit for the MX business unit.? Previously, those concerns came from speculation and outside parties, but with such a high figure in Samsung?s organization worried, it?s clear things are looking pretty bleak. Back in 2013 analysts pegged the profit share of the handset industry at 70 percent for Apple and 30 percent for Samsung. A lot of other smaller companies sold a lot of other phones, but, so that analysis went, none of them made any profits. A lot of them were losing money. I linked to another such analysis in 2016 that pegged Apple?s share of phone profits at 104 percent, estimating that all other handset makers combined accounted for a 4% percent loss. Doesn?t seem l...

7. Understanding the Ubuntu server installer initramfs
Source: Chris's Wiki :: blog | Published: 2026-04-26T02:49:11Z
Link: https://utcc.utoronto.ca/~cks/space/blog/linux/UbuntuServerInstallerInitramfs
I recently wrote about all of the various steps of a UEFI network install , where you have a whole collection of DHCP, GRUB fetching things via TFTP and HTTP, and so on, all to boot into your Ubuntu server install ISO image. Specifically, all of the GRUB stuff and much of the complicated DHCP stuff is there because we have to load the installer's kernel and initial ramdisk. Our primary usage for UEFI network installs is to reinstall physical servers that are now in inconvenient locations, so eventually it occurred to me that if we already have running Linux systems, there are simpler ways to boot into a specific kernel and initramfs with specific command line arguments. One way is to add new GRUB boot entries, and another way is kexec . If we're already using a local kernel and initramfs, it might be convenient to get rid of the need for a DHCP server too, by copying the network parameters from the currently running server and embedding them in both the kernel boot parameters and, more importantly, the cloud-init files that the installer will use. To do this, we need to embed the cloud-init files in the initramfs (and then point to them with 'ds=nocloud;s=/whatever' in the kernel...

8. How Bitwarden Encrypts and Decrypts Secrets
Source: Miguel Grinberg's Blog | Published: Sun, 26 Apr 2026 14:05:41 GMT
Link: https://blog.miguelgrinberg.com/post/how-bitwarden-encrypts-and-decrypts-secrets
As part of my efforts in reducing my dependency on Big Tech, I have been researching how to self-host my password manager. One solution that looks very promising is Vaultwarden , an open source clone of the Bitwarden cloud server. An interesting aspect of this server is that it stores all the secrets in a standard SQLite database, so in addition to having the self-hosted password server I could keep a backup copy of the database on my machine and query it directly. But of course, the secrets are encrypted in this database, so they are useless unless I learn how to decrypt them, similar to how the Bitwarden clients do it. Speaking of the Bitwarden clients, while I was writing this article it came out that the official Bitwarden CLI client was compromised in a supply chain attack. This is a tool that I personally use and have on all my computers, so this feels like a wake up call to me. Luckily I did not install the compromised version myself, but I think there is an argument to be made about rolling your own secret management client instead of relying on the one all the hackers are after! In this article I'll share how the encryption of secrets works in Bitwarden and its Vaultwarde...

9. voice modems
Source: computers are bad | Published: 26 Apr 2026 00:00:00 UT
Link: https://computer.rip/2026-04-26-voice-modems.html
If you’ve done much with modern cellphones, you’ve probably noticed just how odd the architecture can be around audio. Specifically, I mean call audio: modern smartphones have made call audio less of a special case (mostly by just becoming more complicated in general), but in older phones you would often find arrangements where the cellular modem 1 had direct analog audio to the microphone and speaker, perhaps via some switching to share amplifiers. That design meant that the cellular modem functioned basically as a completely independent device, a fully-capable "cellular phone" with the ability to make and receive voice calls. The role of the rest of the smartphone, and its operating system, was just to provide control messages for starting and ending calls. In modern phones the audio path to and from the modem is digital and it’s more integrated into the operating system audio service, but still not fully. You might have noticed, for example, that it is excessively difficult to record call audio on most phones. Regulatory and liability pressures are one reason for this, but another is that it’s actually kind of difficult: there may not be any physical way for software running on...

10. Corona: Delta Update
Source: Bert Hubert’s writings | Published: Tue, 22 Jun 2021 09:00:45 +0200
Link: https://berthub.eu/articles/posts/corona-delta-update/
In de vorige Corona update eind mei schreef ik over ?delta?, toen nog bekend als de Indiase variant: Het is helaas te vroeg om nu een eindoordeel te vellen over deze variant. Wat we wel weten is dat in de UK de vaccins prima standhouden - de overgrote meerderheid van de mensen in het ziekenhuis is ongevaccineerd. Dit is nog steeds waar. Toch weten we nu een stuk meer.

11. Help, My Sin Is Slow and My FPU is Inaccurate
Source: Bert Hubert’s writings | Published: Sat, 19 Jun 2021 14:53:25 +0200
Link: https://berthub.eu/articles/posts/help-my-sin-is-slow-and-my-fpu-is-inaccurate/
Afer 8 years, I have updated this this post for 2021-era Linux (and also to fix bitrotted links). I am extremely joyful to report that the (hard) problem from 2013 appears to have been solved! There is a small addendum at the end to reflect this happy news. Back in 2013, I started writing code to do a simulation of biological system, and I got stuck after 20 lines. My test code tried to go through a million time steps doing basically nothing, and it was taking a minute to do it.

12. Europe’s Software Problem
Source: Bert Hubert’s writings | Published: Tue, 15 Jun 2021 09:56:07 +0200
Link: https://berthub.eu/articles/posts/europes-software-problem/
This article is part of a series on (European) innovation and capabilities. Europe?s communication needs are currently almost exclusively delivered by Chinese hardware that connects us to US-based platforms. For a variety of reasons, this is not a good idea. As stated recently by Charles Michel, President of the European Council, ?Interdependence is natural, even desirable. Over-dependence, however, is not?. Photo by Sara Kurfeßon Unsplash At the core, the problem is that almost no consumer-oriented platforms or software products are being created in Europe, or more precisely, by European companies.